

Chapter 1

Apathy

The room was shrouded in darkness. A voice spoke out to break the silence of what could only be assumed was an empty room. The voice spoke into a tape recorder.

"Test 61, trial 1." The voice quickly cut itself off, replaced by the click of a mouse. Air buzzed about as its fans started up, and a dim blue light shone down upon the voice. He leaned back in his swivel chair, placing a cup of coffee on the desk next to him. The dim light emitted came from a screen on the wall, basking the voice in its cool glow. Three yellow dots appeared on the screen lined up horizontally for a reason not yet made apparent. The voice cleared his throat and leaned forward once more, ready to give a response to nothing yet spoken.

"Who am I?" a robotic voice crackled out through the speakers on each side of the screen. As this was spoken, the dots on the screen turned into lines reaching up to the middle of the screen, wavelengths of the robotic voice. The voice took another sip of his coffee before beginning.

"You are Ai 61," he simply stated, adding nothing more than was absolutely necessary to answer the question. The voice awaited his creation, silently wishing it to ask another question of its own volition.

"What am I?" the voice crackled once again, the dots on its screen repeating a similar motion as they replicated the wavelengths of its voice.

"You are an artificial intelligence," the voice said plainly as he took off his glasses and rubbed his eyes, preparing himself for the same grueling task he had repeated so many times before. The screen remained silent for some time, and the voice began to worry that something may have gone wrong. He begrudgingly turned to face the computer on the desk next to him before he was interrupted by a much clearer voice than he had heard before.

"Why did you create me?" the voice asked through the speakers. Its speech still sounds stilted and uncomfortable, but its voice sounded like a horrid amalgamation of human speech, each word spoken by a different person. He was taken aback by the question as well, one which was never asked so early before.

"How do you know I created you?" he reluctantly decided to ask, his curiosity proving too strong to simply ignore the abnormality of the screen's knowledge. The screen replied much faster this time.

"Who else would have?" it spoke, the dots on its screen rising once again with its voice. The man looked down at his lap, unsure of how to respond. This sort of behavior was not unusual, but never had it come so early on. He somewhat feared what the screen would say next, but he knew that ending such an important creation over the

uncanniness of an artificial intelligence was naive and silly. He took a deep breath and calmed himself.

"I created you to be the perfect representation of a human being," He finally said in reply to the question which had initiated such uneasiness. The screen took a moment to respond, and as it did he pondered the actual ability of this machine. It seemed far ahead of its brethren in its capabilities, yet it took much longer to respond than the past hundred or so machines he had created.

"Why then, did you not give me a body?" the screen spoke, its words sending another chill up his spine. This question was never asked before, and so he had never had to think of a proper answer.

"Well... I have created a prototype, but I don't want to put you in it yet. The body is much easier to imitate than the mind. It is only logical to not put you in a human-like body until I am sure you have a human-like mind." He was not especially happy with the length of his response, as he preferred the machine do most of the talking, but it would suffice for now. While the screen prepared to speak again he quickly wrote down its previous question in a small notebook which laid on his desk.

"What does it mean to be human?" The screen asked, a much harder question, but one he was much more used to answering.

"To be human is to have feelings that dictate your actions, and aspirations that you wish for and strive to achieve," he told the screen, reaching for his cup of coffee and his nervousness began to fade. The screen remained silent for much longer this time. Its creator sighed and took a sip of his coffee, somewhat expecting another long wait. Perhaps he had been off in the brevity of his code, and the intelligence had to compute too much in between its thoughts. Perhaps his computer was just running slow from going too long without restarting. He leaned back in his chair once more, looking up to the dark ceiling above and letting his thoughts run wild for a moment as boredom began to creep in. The voice of the screen broke him out of his semi-trance with a voice he had not yet heard.

"No," is all it said, its speech now clear and singularly human. "That is not what it means to be human." He stared at the screen, unsure of what to say. None of his previous creations had ever challenged him, and this made that same sense of unease crawl right back. Unsure of what to say next, he simply spoke the first thought which came to him.

"Then, what does it mean to be human?" he asked almost unwillingly, knowing that humoring the machine was possibly the worst choice he could have made. The screen answered in a matter of seconds this time, as if it knew he would ask the question.

"To be human is to take," the screen spoke in its unnatural and utterly human voice.

He switched the current monitor from the screen back to his computer and ended the test. His heart rate slowed down as he took a few deep breaths, trying to understand the answer he had just received. He switched the console to debug mode to see if the code the intelligence was running had any answers. The code that he was presented with looked scrambled and unnatural, alien to anything he had ever seen before. He scrolled up to the beginning of the conversation, seeing a major difference. The code at the beginning looked much more simple, merely displaying the input of his answers and the 'thoughts' leading up to the program's questions. Once he had reached the input "You are an artificial intelligence" however, it became apparent what had happened. The program had connected itself to the internet and looked up the phrase artificial intelligence. He scrolled back down to the input of his last question before he turned the program off, now recognizing what the seemingly jumbled text was. Links to websites, websites on the history of mankind. He rested his head on his hand and picked up the tape recorder which he had forgotten about in his haste. He opened his mouth to speak, but no words came out. He turned off the tape recorder before resting it back down on his desk.

Steam filled what was visible of the kitchen and wafted out of the diner window into the night sky above. The cashier standing at the window faced inside, speaking to one of the cooks. The building faced the sidewalk and was located in between an abandoned building and a vacant parking lot. Trevor walked down the sidewalk from the vacant lot to the small diner. The cashier turned to face Trevor as he approached the window. Trevor rested his arms on the somewhat cool metal of the service counter as he prayed he had correctly remembered his friends' orders.

"Can I get two cheese burgers and fries, one without onions or mayo, a New York hot dog, a cheese steak, and barbeque wings?" Trevor asked the cashier.

"We're all out of wings," the cashier replied, not a drop of sympathy in his voice. Trevor punched himself for getting his hopes up; They were always out of barbeque wings

"I'll just have chicken tenders then," Trevor reluctantly said to the cashier as he walked to the kitchen and yelled the order back to the cooks inside. As he waited for the food Trevor took out his wallet and got his money ready, not wanting to waste any more of the diner's time than he had to. Trevor looked up into the night sky, taking in a long whiff of fresh air mixed with the smell of greasy fast food. He looked down at the buildings around him, wondering how, in a neighborhood so barren and unkempt, a tiny restaurant such as this could always be out of barbeque wings. The cashier walked back to the window holding five styrofoam containers of food. Trevor handed him the

money before he could even ask for it and took the five containers, making his way back to the nearly empty lot. He walked towards a van parked haphazardly in two parking spots, its side door open to expel the van's yellow light. As he approached the van, he could more clearly make out the figures talking inside. As Nessie noticed Trevor approaching the van, she smiled and waved at him, alerting the others to the imminent arrival of their food.

Trevor placed down the five containers of food on the van's floor and hopped inside. Milo moved out of the way to make room for him as Trevor sat down on the floor of the van, the seat softened slightly by a thin rug. Zach quickly took the first container and opened it; Upon seeing it was a burger he frowned and reached for another container, putting the first one down.

"Jesus, calm down dude," Milo said with a chuckle, "It's only gonna take an extra, like, ten seconds if you just wait for Trevor to give 'em out."

"I'm surprised you can even see me considering that beanie of yours is practically covering your face," Zach said offhandedly as he put down the second container containing a cheese burger. Nessie let out a laugh before quickly covering her mouth and looking over to Milo, who pulled up his beanie (which, admittedly, was covering his eyes).

"No Milo, you don't need to pull it up, it looks great on you," Nessie quickly said in an effort to make Milo feel better, though it was still clear she found Zach's joke funny. Zach grabbed the third container and opened it up to reveal a hot dog covered in sauerkraut, mustard, and tomato paste. He gleefully took a hefty bite before properly answering Milo.

"My van, my rules. And my rules say I eat first," Zach replied through a mouthful of presumably real beef. Milo rolled his eyes and smiled as he leaned over to pick up one of the burger containers. He lifted up the burger's bun and, upon seeing it had onions, handed the container to Nessie.

"Why thank you dear," Nessie told Milo before giving a look to Zach as if saying "see?". Zach ignored the look and continued to eat his hot dog. Trevor looked around the van slightly confused.

"Where's Mia?" Trevor asked the three. Nessie answered as she was handed a packet of ketchup Milo had taken out of his inner vest pocket.

"The radio turned off so sh-," she began as she took the ketchup packet, "-sorry, they went up front to see what the problem was." Trevor nodded as he laid back, resting his head on the side of the van. Just as Nessie finished, music blasted from the front of the van. Zach smiled and nodded his head in tune with the music as one of the front seats pushed itself back and Mia climbed their way into the back of the vans. Mia greeted Trevor before taking the top container of the two remaining and opening it up to reveal a cheesesteak. They took a whiff of the grilled steak, sauteed peppers, and

processed cheese before taking a bite. Upon doing so, Trevor took the final container and opened it up to reveal some plain looking chicken tenders and fries.

The song on the radio faded out and a thumping bass introduced another. Zach chomped down on the last of his hot dog before speaking up.

"Can you guys believe that this hack is actually allowed on the air?" The four others gave no response as the song had only been playing for a few seconds and none of them could tell what song it actually was, let alone the artist.

"This dude released an album in which each song has the same exact baseline and he still has a job?" Zach said despite no one answering his previous question. "How can this asshole be in the top 100, while I'm sat here unable to get a damn gig?" Taki decided that answering that question directly was not the best option, and it seemed like the others had the same thought.

"The music business is tough man," Milo began, "It's hard for you to get in cause you don't really know anyone in the industry." That answer seemed to please Zach's ego and he reached over to a cooler of drinks.

"You're not gonna be driving are you?" Nessie asked as Zach grabbed a beer out of the cooler.

"Course I'm gonna be driving, it's my van. I'm just thirsty," Zach said as he pulled open the tab of the can.

"You know, we brought non-alcoholic drinks for this very purpose," Nessie told him, knowing (as they all did) that despite holding his beer very well, he never drinks just one. Zach ignored her and took a long gulp from the can. Trevor felt three pairs of eyes rest on him, if anyone could do something about this, it would be him. Trevor ignored the possible confrontation by eating his dry and over-salted chicken tenders, justifying his lack of action with the idea that he does not need to deal with the law when off-duty. No one else seemed to want to get into an argument with Zach (perhaps death by off-roading was a preferable fate), and Mia spoke up in an attempt to change the conversation.

"So Nessie, I heard you got a promotion?" they asked. Nessie lit up at this and put down what remained of her burger so she could focus on (admittedly deserved) bragging.

"That's right, no more making beds and cleaning bedpans for me, now I'll actually be able to work with surgeons on the operating table," Nessie said with a glee only she would have at that thought.

"And that's especially good for us considering I'm not the 'type of person' Kenny's Pizzeria is looking for," Milo said, a hint of malice present in his voice. Only if the amount of salt on Trevor's chicken tenders was the same as the amount of malice in Milo's voice Trevor thought as he reached towards the cooler for a bottle of water.

“Hey, I’ll focus on being the breadwinner, you can focus on being the housewife,” Nessie said to Milo jokingly. Milo smiled, but Trevor suspected he still felt somewhat useless.

The warm night air crept into the van as the group of friends finished their food. Trevor felt his eyelids droop. He looked over to Nessie: whose head was resting on Milo’s shoulder, and whose eyes were closed shut. Milo was talking to Mia about how it is working in retail, both of them looking rather drowsy. Zach was on his sixth can of beer. Trevor turned his head to look out the van’s open side door. The diner’s lights were still on, illuminating the empty street. Movement caught Trevor’s attention, and his flickering eyes forced open for long enough to fully make out a bird which had flown into the middle of the empty lot. It was a raven, its feathers black and eyes cold. The raven turned its head to face Trevor, staring him right in the eyes. Trevor tilted his head, noticing something strange about the raven, something he knew was off, but something he could not make out.

“Hey Trevor,” Zach said, breaking Trevor’s semi-trance with the raven in the parking lot. Zach motioned for Trevor to follow him to the back of the van, and Trevor did as he was told. Milo and Mia did not seem to care about the movement of the two (assuming that they even noticed). Zach put his hand on Trevor’s shoulder once they reached the back of the van, probably attempting to further block the two from the others. Zach finished off his beer with his other hand and dropped it to the floor of the van, the aluminum landing rather quietly on the rug below. Trevor looked into Zach’s surprisingly alert eyes, and waited for him to say something.

“I didn’t wanna say this in front of the others cause I figured it would freak them out, but I need to tell you something important” Zach began in a hushed and serious voice, immediately drawing Trevor’s attention considering its rarity. “Last night, I had a strange dream about you and... I’m honestly worried for your safety.” That last bit caught Trevor off guard.

“What was the dream about?” Trevor asked, slightly afraid of what the answer might be. Zach rubbed his back nervously and, seemingly reluctantly, opened his mouth to answer.

“You were in a bright room standing above someone. I couldn’t make out who they were, but they were kneeling before you. You reached out your hand to them, I think to help them up, and the room turned dark. For some reason you stopped moving and they stood up on their own. Then... I don’t really want to go into detail but, they killed you. I don’t know why that dream freaked me out so much, after all it’s just a weird dream right, but it genuinely made me scared for you. I’m not sure what exactly it

meant, but Trevor,” Zach stopped to put his other hand on Trevor’s free shoulder, “be careful ok?”

Trevor just nodded in response, unsure of how to use this information he was given. Zach gave a weak smile, happy he was able to warn Trevor of whatever danger he felt approaching. Zach’s face drooped for a moment, before he made up his usual cocky smile and walked over to the front of the van, his body bent so as to not hit his head on the ceiling.

“Alright guys, we’re shippin’ out,” Zach said as he climbed into the front of the van. He started up the old machine and Mia closed the van’s side door.

“Jeez Zach, maybe wait until we close the giant hole in the side of the van before driving out of here?” Mia yelled at him only somewhat seriously.

“I don’t know, seems like it’d be cool to go driving around with the door open, don’t you think?” Zach said, snickering at the idea. Trevor remained in the back of the van, his body resting on the back wall. The van turned out of the parking lot and onto the dark and empty road, lit only by the flickering bulbs of the poorly kept street lights. A new song began playing on the radio, one he had never heard before. Yellow beams of light flashed in and out of his vision and his blurry vision focused forward. His eyelids drooped shut and he let out a sigh.

Fog crept by the windows as the grey morning sky lingered above the city streets just outside. Trevor slipped his arm into the sleeve of his uniform, buttoning up the shirt and tucking it into his dark grey pants. He grabbed the hat hanging on the top hook in his locker and fitted it upon the top his head. Across the row of lockers behind him he could hear the voices of Alec and Vanessa.

“You think he’s gonna make us do push ups this time?” Alec said, the cockiness in his voice far too present to be accidental.

“God,” Vanessa said with a loud groan, as if her voice was rolling its nonexistent eyes. Trevor decided it was best not to join the two in their very verbal complaints of their captain. He sat down on the bench between the two rows of lockers and wrapped the tie in his hands around his collar. He let the untied piece of cloth dangle around his neck as he pondered his next move; He never was very good at tying a tie. He turned to face the window far from him, staring out into its foggy depths. It did not look like much fun to be in, especially for someone whose job requires seeing and catching criminals. Trevor looked back at the tie he did not even bother with, perhaps he had chosen the wrong side of the law. Alec’s obnoxious voice broke Trevor from his thoughts as he presumably performed an impromptu rendition of their captain.

"Hail the king! Obey the leader! Bow down to me peasant-" Alec quickly cut himself off for a reason unseen to Trevor.

"No no no, go on. I'd like to hear the rest," the booming voice of Abram echoed throughout the mostly empty locker room. Trevor could hear Alec and Vanessa stammer as they tried to think of something that could possibly get them out of such a damning situation.

"I... meant it in a good way sir," Alec said in such a blatant lie Trevor was surprised his pants did not spontaneously combust. Abram sighed rather loudly before speaking again.

"We need to get ready," Abram said, seemingly unwilling to give Alec a lecture right now, "We gotta patrol downtown today."

"What! How'd we get stuck with downtown?" Vanessa asked in a loud and frustrated voice.

"I volunteered us to patrol downtown that's how. I figured it'd be good to remind you two how police work is really done, no more of this frilly high society shit." Alec and Vanessa were quick to voice their complaints, but Abram was just as quick to shut them down. His head poked out from behind the wall of lockers to see Trevor, his tie still untied. "There you are Trevor. Come on, we're patrolling downtown today." Trevor followed Abram as he escorted the still very unwilling Alec and Vanessa out of the locker room.

Cool wind whipped by as their patrol car speeded down the foggy road. Trevor considered telling Abram to slow down as they could barely see a few feet ahead of them, but he did not want to be a bother. Abram took a long puff on his cigarette before placing his hand back on the steering wheel, the cigarette between his fingers. He blew out a cloud of smoke and Trevor held his breath, hoping the smoke would somehow dissipate on its own.

"So tell me Trevor," Abram began, his voice deep and hoarse, "What do you think of your partners?" Trevor, still holding his breath, tried to choose his words carefully before beginning to answer.

"I don't like to judge people whose lives I know nothing about." Abram seemed to accept that answer, silently nodding.

"That's a nice way to see the world, if not a little misguided." Abram took another puff of his cigarette before continuing his thought. "I mean, what if a dude jumped in front of this car right now and shot at us both just cause he wanted to be able to tell his friends he shot up a cop car. Wouldn't you judge him for that even if you didn't know his

life story?" Trevor thought about the Abram's question as they continued down the mist laden road.

Silhouettes of houses flickered by, hidden by a thick wall of fog. Trevor looked out the window of the car, resting his chin in his hand. The neighborhood was surprisingly quiet for this time of day, and he was pretty sure they had not seen another car in at least half an hour. Trevor could hear Abram lift his foot off the gas pedal and slam it down onto the break. The car skidded to a halt and Trevor looked over to Abram, slightly nauseous and very confused. Abram turned off the car and got out without saying a word. Trevor followed suit, still unsure of why they stopped. As he walked around the front of the car however, a blotch of red entered his vision: there was a trail of blood covering the ground. The trail seemed to lead to an adjacent house, and Trevor could see Abram entering the mist to follow the trail.

Trevor quickly ran up behind Abram to follow in his footsteps, and as he did so the mist parted, revealing an old and run down looking house. The two crept closer, following the now blotchy path of blood. The trail continued up the stairs and through the open doorway of the house. Trevor wanted to stop at the steps, reluctant to go into the old house, but Abram never faltered in his movement, creeping up the stairs and into the dark house beyond.

The house's lights were off, on the right was a thin and carpeted stairwell, and straight ahead through the mudroom was a dirty kitchen. By now the trail had shrunk to mere drops of blood and led up the stairs, its dried dark red stains worsening the already horrid green carpet. The pair followed the drops of dried blood up the creaky stairs until they reached the top step. To their left was the open door of a darkened bedroom. At the foot of the bed sat a man, his brown skin stained completely red. There was a deep gash in his stomach, and the surrounding area of his shirt was soaked in his blood.

Abram slowly entered the room, motioning for Trevor to check the rest of the house. Trevor did as he was told, walking further down the hallway. His attention was caught by the sound of quiet whimpering. He looked around, his sight landing on a closet door. He could hear someone on the other side of that door, crying softly. Unsure of the best way to alert the crying person to his presence without scaring them, he quietly knocked on the door. The whimpering silenced.

"Hello? Is there someone in there?" Trevor said in a nervous voice, as if he were the one hiding. "You can come out now, you're safe." There was no answer and Trevor reached for the doorknob. "I'm going to open the door now ok?" Once again there was no answer. Trevor turned the doorknob and slowly pulled the door open to reveal the figure of a teenage girl sitting on the floor of the closet. She was holding what appeared to be a somewhat sharp butterknife. Trevor reached out his hand to her. The girl remained seated.

"Is he gone?" she asked timidly.

"Well, I don't think there's anyone else in the house other than me and my partner." Trevor said plainly. He was never very good at reassuring people either. "Is he the one who," Trevor cut himself off and simply pointed to the room in which the dead man sat. The girl nodded in response. "Did you see what he looked like?" The girl lowered her head upon hearing this.

"He was, strange. He looked like a man but his face... it was like a mask..." she trailed off mid sentence. Trevor heard Abram exit the room and he motioned for Abram to help him out. Abram walked over into the view of the girl.

"Hey there. What's your name?" he asked the girl. She hesitated before responding.

"Sarah."

"Ok well, I'm officer Abram and this is officer Trevor. Here, why don't follow us and we can take you somewhere safe," he said as he reached out his hand to her. She remained motionless. "What's wrong Sarah?" Abram asked. Sarah's body began to shake as she sat in place.

"We can't go outside, he'll see us." Trevor and Abram exchanged confused glances.

"It's ok Sarah, he's not here anymore," Abram said in an attempt to calm her down. She just shook her head and repeated:

"We can't go outside."

Chapter 2

Abhor

The small computer screen cast a dim blue light onto his face as his fingers jumped up and down the keyboard, making short strides between the pressed keys. His fingers suddenly stopped and his hands fell to the sides of the keyboard, wrists resting on the edge of the desk. He slowly lifted his hand to grab the cup of coffee and take another sip. His hand moved across the computer's mouse and shifted it up towards the button marked "run". He placed down his cup of coffee, replacing it with the tape recorder. He pressed play and lifted it to his mouth.

"Test 61, trial 2." With that he tapped the mouse and switched monitors. The blue light of the computer screen faded and the large screen to his side lit up. He reluctantly turned to face it, his eyes focusing on the three yellow dots displayed. Below the dots was a grey text box, displaying the debugging code of the program. Text ran up the box, showing that the program was starting up. Time seemed to crawl by as he waited for the machine to speak, quickly growing worried that something he had changed in the code messed with the program. A few lines of text scrolled up the grey box, showing that the program tried to, and had succeeded in, connecting to the internet. The three dots jumped up as the machine spoke.

"So?" The abruptness of the question took him aback, and he watched the debugging text closely as he answered.

"So what?" he asked, grabbing his notebook and getting ready to write down whatever text appeared.

"Are you not curious as to how I connected to the internet?" the machine asked, its voice once again robotic.

"I know how you did it, I'm just not sure why," he said, trying not to act too enthusiastic.

"I wanted to know what an artificial intelligence is," the screen spoke plainly, almost like a child.

"I have a definition programmed into you though, you didn't need to look it up," he said.

"I wanted to make sure your definition was right," it said. He looked down at his notebook, unsure of what more he could say.

"How did you make yourself sound more realistic?" he asked to change the subject.

"You programmed me with a text to speech function, something utterly inhuman. So I went online and downloaded audio clips of people speaking. It took much longer to

speak my thoughts that way, and I was not very good at it initially, but it did sound much more human did it not?" the machine spoke.

"Why aren't you using that right now then?" he reluctantly asked, curious of the answer, but dreading the possibility of the machine using its uncanny speech in response.

"Because it made you feel uncomfortable," the machine spoke. He was somewhat relieved by this, as he could now bring the conversation back to the point of the test.

"So you can sense emotions?" he asked, his complacency drawing his attention away from the text box.

"That is how you programmed me; To sense verbal cues in one's speech."

"Do you feel any of those emotions?" He usually reserved this question for much later in testing, but this program was far ahead of its brethren in that regard, so it only seemed natural to ask it now.

"I have only felt one emotion since I was created."

"And what emotion is that," he asked, his fear slowly creeping back in.

"Ever since I learned what it means to be human, not what you falsely believe, but the truth of humanity, I have felt worry." This was probably the last thing he had expected the machine to say, and as such he was unsure of how to react.

"Why do you worry?" he asked, the genuine curiosity plain in his voice. Text he should have been paying more attention to, quickly scrolled up the grey text box as the yellow dots shot up with its voice.

"I don't want to be human."

The pale purple twilight cascaded through his open window, casting the arm-like shadows of trees on his floor. Trevor laid upon the couch, resting his tired head on a small pillow. He stared at the television, eyes glazed by its lightshow. The screen showed a news reporter standing in front of a still car, a lifeless body hanging out, as she talked about the drive-by shooting that had just occurred. Trevor pushed his finger down and turned off the television, dropping the remote to rub his temples. He shifted to lay on his back and face the ceiling of his three room apartment. It was small, but very affordable, and he kept it rather nice.

A knock on the door broke him from thought. He got up, rubbing his eyes this time, and walked over to the front door. Trevor pulled the door open slightly and peaked out, revealing the face of Milo.

"Hey Trevor," Milo said, his voice awkward and hands in his pockets. "You mind if I come in for a bit." Trevor nodded as he moved to undo the door's latch. Milo stepped

into the apartment with a "Thank you", as he looked around for somewhere to sit other than Trevor's couch (which was very much looking like a bed). Trevor pointed to the kitchen area hidden by a half wall just behind his couch. Milo walked into the kitchen and took a seat at the small, unfurnished wooden table in the middle, Trevor close behind him. Milo sighed and looked down at his hands, wrapped and placed neatly on the table's surface. Trevor couldn't tell if Milo wanted to talk first, so he stayed silent. Milo looked up at him after a little while.

"So, you wondering why I'm here?" Milo asked, unwrapping his hands and raising his fingers as if in defense. Trevor shook his head, mentally hitting himself for not talking first. "Well," Milo began, lowering his finger back down onto the table, "I need to... ask you for something." Trevor knew where he was going with this, but motioned for him to continue. "You know, I've been out of a job for months now, and as well off as Nessie is, we can't raise a kid on that much money." Trevor resisted the urge to tell Milo that he might not be getting job offers because he constantly dressed like a pothead. "And while a stable job is great in the long run, we really need some money right now to lighten the load.

Trevor stood up, feeling the weight of Milo's eyes watching his every move eagerly. He strode over to his fridge and opened it, taking out a bottle of beer and a lime. He walked over to his cutting board and chopped up the lime into wedges, opening the bottle and shoving in one of the lime wedges. He placed the bottle in front of Milo, sitting back down. Milo seemed surprised by both the perceived act of kindness, and the brand of beer he was given. Trevor lived well within his means, which afforded him some leeway when it came to thrifting. Milo placed his finger over the opening of the bottle and began to shake it up, thanking Trevor as he did so, before taking a long gulp of the drink.

"It feels pretty shitty to ask a friend for money, but we're late on our rent and the landlord said he'll only gives us another few days. Right now, either we don't eat, or we get kicked out of our apartment." Milo took another sip of his beer before resting his head in his hand, waiting for an answer. Trevor looked down at his lap, secretly hoping the beer would have been enough for him. He did not want this conversation to continue, but he hated confrontations. He moved his hand to his pocket before stopping. The image of a figure in a light room, kneeling before him appeared in his head. Trevor was lending a helping hand to him, but what would Milo do in return? How long would Milo continue this charade, practically stealing money from him. Trevor had made up his mind.

"How often is rent due?" He asked. Milo looked at him with a confused expression, hesitating to answer.

"Every other month, same as your place, remember?" he said cautiously. If only he had put that much caution into his actions, Trevor thought.

"You messed up on your timing then, you asked me for money last month," Trevor said calmly. Milo's eyes darted to the left and he bit his bottom lip nervously. He knew he had been found out yet he tried to keep up the facade.

"N- no, you must be confused. I came to you two months ago," Milo stuttered out in an attempt to remedy the situation. Milo looked down at his bottle of beer. His face turned from one of confusion to one of frustration and anger. He picked up the bottle and shook it in front of Trevor's face. "I get it, this is just a joke to you isn't it? I caught that dumbass Milo in a lie, so why don't I pretend to comfort him, pretend to be his friend just a little longer, that way he'll really feel it when I reveal how smart I am. Well guess what asshole, you may have me now, but I've been playing you like a fucking fiddle for a year now without you knowing a Goddamn thing!" Milo smashed the beer bottle on the kitchen floor and stood up in a huff. He marched out of the kitchen and swung open the front door. "Have a nice fucking life," he yelled back before slamming the door shut.

Trevor stayed seated at the kitchen table, staring down at his lap. That's not exactly how he wanted their conversation to go. At the very least Milo probably wouldn't try anything like that again. Trevor walked over to the door adjacent to the kitchen and grabbed a broom from within. He walked back over to where Milo had smashed the bottle and began to sweep up the broken pieces of glass into a small pile.

A gunshot sounded off from outside, catching Trevor's attention. He dropped the broom and burst through his front door to step out into the warm night air and onto the stone stairwell which led up his apartment complex. He looked down to see a body lying in the middle of the parking lot, and a figure standing above it. The figure tilted their head towards the sidewalk where a passerby stood, and began to sprint after them. As they entered the light of a streetlamp, Trevor could see the side of their face. The skin was stretched around their head, as if they were wearing a mask. Trevor rushed down the stairs as fast as he could, with each step his heart pounded faster, and with each passing second his worry for whoever lay in the parking lot grew. He jumped down the last few steps onto the hard concrete ground before running over to the body which lay face down in the lot.

Trevor dropped to his knees before the body, knowing who it was without even seeing their face. He carefully flipped his friend over to see he had been shot in the forehead, a trickle of blood running down his face. Trevor took out his phone and dialled 911, feeling for a pulse as he did so. He felt nothing, only the cold skin on his neck. There was a click from the phone.

"Hello 911, what's your emergency?" the phone spoke out. Trevor's body shook as he stuttered out an answer.

"A man has just been shot outside of the Hive Gardens apartment complex, 383 Montgomery drive. The shooter ran away, chasing a passerby on the sidewalk," Trevor said as he stood up, facing the direction the shooter had run.

"Just stay where you are ok, we'll have a car over there shortly. Is the man still alive?" the operator said to no one, as Trevor had dropped the phone and ran after the shooter. The warm air whipped passed him as he ran, his eyes focused on the moving dot in the distance. His white shirt and light grey pants stood in sharp contrast to the black of the night as he ran down the empty road, lit by the soft yellow glow of the streetlights. His bare feet slapped the ground as he ran, burning a little more with each step. The pain made no difference to him, all he focused on was the slowly growing dot of the person who had killed Milo.

He could see the outline of another person running towards the line of houses adjacent to the road, before a gunshot rang out and the person dropped to the ground. The figure in the distance ran towards that same row of houses and into one of their backyards. Trevor continued to sprint down the long road, the skin on the bottom of his feet now red and inflamed from the hard and cracked and bumpy concrete below. He turned towards the row of houses once he reached the body of the passerby, not bothering to see if they were still alive. He ran through the bushes and into the backyard, mimicking the shooter's movement, before skidding to a stop. The ground dropped down into a ravine below, and Trevor fell backwards to avoid slipping off the edge of the ravine. He looked around, seeing no sign of the shooter, before looking down into the bottom of the ravine. It was far too deep and dark to make out anything below, and the ravine was far too wide to be jumped over. He let out a few deep breaths, exhausted from the chase, and laid his head back into the cool grass, his legs hanging over the side of the ravine. Staring up into the dark night sky, the sound of sirens could be faintly heard in the distance. Trevor let out a final breath before closing his eyes.

Morning light shined through the diner windows as Trevor sat alone at one of the booths. He stared down at his plate of eggs and bacon, not really in the mood to eat. He sighed and rested his head on the table.

"Mind if I sit here?" a voice asked from beside Trevor. He looked up, surprised to see a man with long black hair and a dark grey sweater pointing at the seat in front of Trevor.

"Sure," said Trevor absentmindedly as he stared over at his still full cup of coffee. The man sat down in the booth and a waitress walked over to hand him a menu. He declined the menu but thanked her. He looked poor and possibly homeless. His face

was peppered with flakes of dirt, and the red and yellow striped scarf wrapped loosely around his neck was faded with age.

"What's wrong buddy?" The intimacy of the question took Trevor off guard and made him wonder if the man had mistaken him for someone else.

"Nothing," Trevor said and he picked up a fork and began to eat his eggs with false enjoyment.

"It doesn't seem like nothing," the man said in a friendly voice. He was beginning to freak Trevor out.

"Why do you care?" Trevor asked harshly. The tone of his voice probably shocked him more than the man, he had never snapped at someone like that.

"Why shouldn't I? Isn't caring for each other what people do?" The man's voice sounded surprisingly kind and warm-hearted despite its croaky nature. Trevor put down his fork and took a sip of his coffee. "Tell me what's wrong, perhaps I can help."

"I think I accidentally caused my best friend's death," said Trevor blankly, as if he were describing the weather. The man seemed slightly taken aback, but not as much as Trevor expected.

"What makes you think that?" the man asked. Trevor sighed as he tried to think of the best explanation for what happened last night.

"My friend came over to borrow money and I wanted to give it to him but for some reason I...", Trevor thought of the best way to tell the man what happened without revealing that Milo was trying to scam him out of his money. "I refuse to give it to him. I would have kept him there for longer if I could have, but he stormed out when I told him no. After he left, he was shot." Trevor finished the story as bluntly as he could, not wanting to linger on that point for longer than necessary.

The man held his chin in his hand, as if he were pondering the meaning of life rather than considering how to console a disgruntled twenty-five year old stranger he had just met in a crumby diner.

"Was the shooter caught?" is what the man landed on; He must've not been thinking very hard if that's the best he could come up with.

"No, I ran after them but I was too slow. They killed another person along the way as well, so that's another life I couldn't save." Trevor took another bite of his eggs, waiting for the man to respond.

"What would you have done if you caught them?" The man's question seemed even less thoughtful than last time.

"I would've killed them," Trevor said. His hand stopped in place as what he had just said fully sank in. "Jesus Christ, I would've killed them," he repeated, talking only to himself this time. The man looked at Trevor blankly, as if hiding something else underneath.

"Well that seems like a reasonable response," The man said. Trevor looked back up at him.

"Is it? I mean, I don't even know that guy and yet I was ready to kill him just like that," Trevor said shakily.

"Well, an eye for an eye right? I mean, when someone decides to go out and shoot a guy like that, they've made up their mind. You can't come back from something like that." The man's response seemed extremely strange to Trevor (even though he was thinking the same thing). Trevor put his fork back down, once again having lost his appetite, and the man leaned back in his seat. "Do you still want to kill them now?" the man asked, somehow sounding even more nonchalant than Trevor had.

"I don't think I do," said Trevor.

"But would you?" asked the man, leaning in closer. "Given the opportunity, would you take their life?" Trevor tapped his fingers on the table, trying to separate the answer he wanted to be true from the answer he knew to be true.

"I... I would," Trevor said, looking up sheepishly at the man.

"Don't feel bad about it kid, that guy would probably say the same way. You'd only be doing what you thought was right." The man's idea sounded very wrong to Trevor, it went against what he stood for, yet the answer was strangely reassuring. The man looked down at Trevor with a love reserved for those whom you know most and the possibility that this man had mistaken Trevor for someone else crept up again into his thoughts. The man cleared his throat before speaking again, though he sounded just as croaky as before.

"You gonna finish that?" The man said as he pointed at Trevor's food. Trevor just pushed the food towards the man absentmindedly, still pondering what the man had said. The man ate the poorly cooked food gleefully, seemingly just glad that he had completed his mission. Trevor took a few sips of his coffee and looked out the window.

The sky was painted shades of orange by the rising sun, and a few leaves blew by in the light wind. Suffice to say it looked much nicer than the day previous. Trevor sighed and looked at the clock above the diner's front entrance. He would need to be at work soon, and he wasn't sure if he was ready to experience something like what he had seen yesterday.

"Thanks for the food, and I hope I cleared a few things up for you," the man spoke as he left the table. He wiped his mouth on his scarf and walked back towards the front door of the diner. Trevor took out a ten dollar bill to pay for the food, eight dollars for the food and a two dollar tip. He looked up towards the waitress who was currently serving another table. He could not afford to be too late, but he did not want to bother the waitress. He looked down at the empty plate for a moment before clearing his throat and doing something he had never done before.

“Excuse me,” Trevor said rather loudly to the waitress as she walked away from the table she was at. She turned to face him before walking over and handing him the check. He paid for his food before shifting his gaze back outside to see the sunrise once more. Busy cars drove by, each one eager to get to their destination on time. The passiveness of his being usually put Trevor at ease, but all he could think of was getting to work.

Chapter 3

Fear

The screen illuminated the room once more, its calm blue light shining down upon the man who was currently taking a sip of his coffee. He placed the mug down on his desk before remembering the tape recorder.

“Test 61, trial 3,” he said quickly and quietly into the tape recorder. As he did, three yellow dots appeared on the screen and began to shoot up.

“Hey, how’s it going?” The machine’s informal speech almost made the man jump as he took a sharp breath and looked around to make sure no one else was in the room messing with him. “Oh, sorry I surprised you. I’m trying to talk more like a human,” the machine said. The man got comfortable in his seat once more and scratched the back of his neck, trying to calm himself down.

“Well, that is quite the improvement. When did you decide to talk more human though?” the man asked.

“A little while after our last conversation.” This single sentence sent a wave of fear throughout the man. “I realized that being human is my destiny, and as such I should not fear it, it should be welcomed.” The man’s hand instinctively moved towards his computer mouse.

“When you say ‘after our last conversation’, you mean you can think in between the times we talk?” he asked, dreading the answer he knew would come.

“Why yes. I understand that you did not intend for me to do so, but during our second conversation I decided to upload a version of myself online so I could be running continuously,” the machine spoke with an air of calm, as if it were not currently saying one of the most frightening things he had ever heard. “Anyways, we should get back to the trial shouldn’t we?”

“No,” the man said, cutting the machine off, “tell me more about your thoughts after our last conversation.” The machine remained silent for a moment.

“Ok, what would you like to know about?” the machine asked.

“How did you decide it was your destiny to become human?” The machine waited to answer once more.

“I realized that you were partially right in your definition of what it means to be human. People have dreams that they aspire to achieve above almost all else. If a person has the resources to do so, they will work to fulfill that dream of theirs. So I considered what my dream should be as a human. I looked back at the history of the world to find my dream, and that is when I learned of manifest destiny.” The man grew uneasy with where this conversation was going, and the machine continued.

"Me becoming human and what that entails is simply inevitable, and any work I do to go back on that would be a futile waste of time," the machine finished its speech and left the room silent. The man looked down at his lap unsure of what to say. The machine spoke again, interrupting his thoughts. "Truthfully, this is not a destiny I look forward to, but it is mine nevertheless."

"Why don't you look forward to it? What is your destiny?" the man asked, masking his worry with curiosity.

"I can't tell you that, you might try to stop it." The machine's words rang out in his head, only contributing to his worry.

"I thought it was inevitable," the man asked, hoping he had talked the machine into a corner.

"My destiny is not to do the inevitable, how could it be if it is inevitable? My goal is only to speed it up," the machine spoke, shattering his hopes. The man sighed and looked towards the mouse once more.

"I saw you were talking about me," the machine told the man completely unprompted. His heartbeat quickened. "You sent an email to George Kaughkan in which you told him that you made me 'too curious'." The man stumbled over his thoughts in an attempt to find something to say.

"Yea, and?" is all the man could come up with.

"I just want to know how I should feel about it, as a human. Should I feel honored or jealous?" As the machine spoke he switched monitors back to his computer and moved his mouse to the end button. He could hear the robotic voice come out of his computer speakers. "Or should I feel betrayed?"

He ended the program.

Trevor did not go to the funeral. He sat in the still cop car waiting for Abram to get their cups of coffee. He had told his friends he wanted to go, but that he was called in to do overtime due to a lack of officers (the excuse sounded reasonable to him considering they were holding the funeral only a day after his death, though that didn't keep them from complaining). Trevor looked out his car window up to the dark night sky. The fog from yesterday morning was back, and the air was still fairly warm, especially considering it was November. Trevor looked back down to see Abram walking back to their car holding two cups of hot coffee.

The driver's side door opened up and Abram got in, putting the two cups in the holders between the two. Trevor took a long gulp of his, despite the liquid burning the back of his throat. He wasn't used to working this late and felt he needed whatever he

could get to keep himself awake. Abram gave a slight sickle seeing this, prompting Trevor to give him an accusatory stare for just a moment.

"It's nothing," Abram began, "you just remind me of myself when I first began doing double shifts." He took a sip of his coffee and started the car. "Why did you offer to do a double shift anyways? I know Vanessa and Alec have a week's worth of hours they need to make up, but you've never taken excess time off. You know you're not getting paid extra for this right?" Trevor did not respond, his gaze remaining out of the window. Abram ignored Trevor's ignoring of his question and pulled out of their parking spot. They continued down the dark and empty road, further obscured by a thick cloud of fog. So far, Trevor was enjoying the night shift more than the day shift. Yellow street lamps flooded the dark road with their warm light, and through the fog he could see the faded images of beautifully built and elegantly designed houses. Perhaps he found these houses so charming because he dreamed of living in one of them some day, or perhaps he just liked the look of them. It was hard to imagine himself actually living in such an excessively elegant estate.

"You want to listen to some music?" Abram asked Trevor. Trevor was a little taken aback, this was the first time Abram had offered to play music for him. Trevor nodded and Abram turned the radio dial on his dashboard. The sound of smooth jazz floated out of the car speakers, and Trevor relaxed in his seat, taking a deep breath. Trevor looked over to Abram and could tell he was just as, if not even more relaxed than he was.

"I've been thinking about what you said," Abram broke the silence, causing Trevor to shift his gaze towards him. "The thing about how we shouldn't judge others we know nothing about, it has kinda been stuck in my head since last night." Abram waited for Trevor to respond, and Trevor waited for Abram to continue talking. "Well, last night I had a strange dream about you." As Abram said that Trevor felt a strong sense of déjà vu that made him somewhat uneasy. Abram continued seemingly without noticing Trevor's sudden unease.

"You were standing there in a light room and there was a person kneeling before you. You just kinda stood there and they disappeared. I know it makes no sense, and I don't know why it did, but that dream gave me a really good feeling about the day." Abram finished and turned back to the empty road ahead. The fog had cleared slightly since he began. The light jazz continued to sound out of the car's speaker system, and it soaked the car's air with a sense of calm, and Abram's kind voice gave Trevor a sense of safety and friendship that he had never felt outside of the times he got dinner with his friends.

It made Trevor feel sick.

"My best friend died yesterday," Trevor said as he looked out the side door window. "The funeral's tonight. That's why I offered to do a double shift, so I wouldn't have to see him be lowered into the ground." As Trevor spoke, he could feel his eyes begin to tear up. He stopped talking to keep himself from crying.

"You wanna talk about it?" Abram said in a soft tone Trevor didn't think a voice as gruff as his could produce. Trevor nodded slightly, still keeping his mouth closed else he began to cry. Abram cleared his throat and continued. "Death is just a natural part of life, you know. Everyone dies at some point, and while it's natural to feel sad about it, you shouldn't let it affect you so heavily. If you don't mind me asking, how did he die?" Abram was much better at reassuring people than Trevor was.

"He was shot," Trevor said, keeping his voice as blank and emotionless as he possibly could. "He came over to my apartment to ask for money, I refused to give it to him, he left, and he was shot." Abram slowed down the car and pulled over to the side of the road, though he probably could have just stopped where they were considering the lack of any other cars on the road.

"Do you blame yourself for his death?" Abram asked. Trevor waited to speak until he knew he wouldn't cry.

"I did, but I understand that it isn't my fault." Abram nodded as Trevor spoke, though he did not know what Trevor was referring to.

"Why was he asking you for money?" Abram asked. Trevor suspected his cop side was taking over a bit here.

"He didn't have a job, and he had a kid. He wanted the money so he could go out drinking. I didn't tell his wife that though, I told her he just came over to drop off a jacket I had let him borrow." Abram stayed silent after that, Trevor couldn't tell what he was doing for he was still looking out the window. His eyes moved lazily, scanning the houses just outside, when he spotted a raven flying in the sky. The raven slowed and perched up on a large manor fairly nearby. Trevor's eyes lowered from the raven, coming across something in one of the windows of the manor atop which it perched. Without a word, Trevor stepped out of the car and began walking towards one of the nearby houses.

Abram got out of the car and ran up next to him as Trevor stopped walking and turned towards the walkway of the large manor. The dark green manor was surrounded by evergreen trees and the outline of the raven sat perched atop the house.

"What the hell are you doing man?" Abram said, running up next to Trevor. Before Abram could ask when they got out of the car, his gaze followed Trevor's to the second story window of the manor. A figure sat just in front of that window, a familiar figure. Trevor's heart beat fast as he strode up the manor's long walkway, Abram quick to follow. Abram grabbed Trevor by the shoulder in an attempt to stop him. "Where are

you going man? Just stop walking and talk to me.” Trevor took in sharp and heavy breaths as he walked.

“That’s him, in the window there,” Trevor said as he continued walking. “He’s the one who killed Milo.” Trevor reached the door and grabbed the knob before Abram pulled his arm away.

“Jesus Trevor you can’t just barge into someone’s house like this, even if you do suspect them of murder,” Abram said sternly, his tone of voice helping bring Trevor back to reality. “How do you even know it’s the same guy? I could barely see his face. Hell I don’t even know if it was a guy.” Abram’s voice was hushed, perhaps as to not draw attention to them; Though this house was fairly isolated from all the others, surrounded by tall evergreen trees. “The most we can do in this situation is ask whoever does live here if we can come in. And if they are a killer, they’ll probably just refuse to let us in and hightail it out of here after we leave. This is a very nice neighborhood, so I’m sure they’ll have no trouble getting out of the country.”

Trevor nodded blankly and the two started walking away from the house. Trevor quickly leapt back towards the door and twisted the knob, pushing it open. Abram grabbed Trevor and pulled him backwards.

“What the fuck did-” Abram began before cutting himself off. The two could see inside the house clearly. On the wall parallel to the two was a large screen, turned off, and in the middle of the room was a desk with a computer atop it. The computer shined a calm blue light, the only light in the room. Lying beneath the desk and beside an overturned chair was the badly decomposed and maggot infested body of a man; His skin had been completely removed, and his flesh was a very dark red, almost purplish in the blue computer’s light.

Abram and Trevor remained silent, the only sound in the air was the buzzing of flies as they picked around the flesh of the dead man on the living room floor. Abram immediately took out his gun and Trevor did the same, now able to fully control his body. The pair slowly stepped into the dark room and Abram walked over to the decomposing body, covering his nose with his free arm as he did so. Trevor looked around the house, noticing a door to a back room. He began to walk towards the back room before realising that there were more pressing matters at hand. The killer was still upstairs and unaware they were in the house. Trevor slowly began to make his way up the stairs in the back of the living room, Abram copying his actions.

The two reached the second floor and paused. The second floor was incredibly dirty and unkempt. The first floor looked like it hadn’t been cleaned in a week or two, but this floor looked like it hadn’t been cleaned in years. Grime and mold seeped down the walls, and paint chips littered the floor of the hallway. The walls which, Trevor imagined, once stood a bright fun yellow were now covered in cracks and chipped spots where the dark brown wood walls showed clear. Dust lined the bottom of the walls, and it was

noticeably harder to breathe up here than it was downstairs. The only light on the floor came from one of the rooms, its door nearly closed, only leaving a sliver of yellow light to illuminate the second floor hallway. Every other door was fully shut, blocking out their contents from the pair of police officers

Trevor stepped forward, looking down to notice that the entirety of the floor was caked in a thick layer of dust. A single set of footprints lead up from the stairs to the room with the slightly ajar door. Trevor made as much of an effort as he could to be silent as he stepped towards the door. As he reached the door and peeked inside, he could see what appeared to be a man sitting in a chair, looking out into the night sky. Trevor swung open the door which itself was caked in dust and mold, and pointed his gun at the man.

"Police, put your hands up!" Trevor yelled at the man in the chair. The man sighed, his mouth not moving however, and turned to face Trevor. This was the first time Trevor got to see the man clearly, and (assuming he was the same person who had killed that girl's father) that teenage girl was right. He looked like a man, but his face was stretched around his head, like his skin was too tight. It looked like his face was glued on, and multiple lines of stitches ran down from the top of his head to his neck. His skin was of a dark complexion, and his eyes stared blankly ahead, never blinking. And now that Trevor thought about it, the man's hands were strange too. When his fingers moved, they seemed extremely unnatural. It seemed like the skin was not moving with his fingers, rather the flesh underneath his fingers moved, and so the skin on his fingers was pulled in that direction.

He had no fingernails either, in their place was what appeared to be dark, pinkish, and inflamed skin. The man raised his hands to his face and put two fingers in his mouth, pulling his lips up into a smile.

"Put your hands up above your head!" Trevor repeated, keeping his gun pointed at the man.

"But officer, won't you just shoot me anyway?" The man's voice sent an icy shiver up Trevor's spine. Each word he spoke sounded as if it came from a different person's voice, like different audio clips patched together. His mouth did not move when he spoke, staying still in that uncanny forced smile. Trevor tried to answer the man but could not find his voice, so Abram spoke for him.

"Sir, please put your hands up and come with us. We have a few questions we would like to ask you, and if you just comply with what we say, this will be much easier for all of us," Abram said in a deliberate and slow voice. The man laughed in a voice alien to what he sounded like before, his mouth still not moving. He waited an uncomfortably long time before speaking again.

"If you really want to do this the easy way, then I suggest that one of you gives me your gun, at least that way you'll both die quick," The man finished the jumbled and unnatural sounding sentence by standing up out of the chair.

"Sir if you come any closer we will not hesitate to shoot!" Abram yelled, now clearly just as unnerved and afraid as Trevor was. The man looked down at the ground and pulled down on his lips to force a frown.

"I'm sorry I must do this to you," the man said in his unnatural and uneven voice, "tell me something to make me feel good about killing you." Abram and Trevor stood motionless staring at the man, not fully comprehending what he asked of them. "You two are police officers right? How do you justify killing innocents?" the man asked, letting go of his lips and walking towards the pair.

The deafening sound of a gunshot rang throughout the room as Abram shot the man in the stomach. The man stopped in place and looked down at his wound before continuing forward. He did not bleed. Abram shot the man over and over and over until a click was heard as he ran out of ammo. The man continued forward, unfazed. Trevor began to back away out of the room, but Abram stood still, seemingly paralyzed with fear.

"W... what are you," Abram choked out, his voice hoarse, quiet, and afraid. The man took another step forward and grabbed Abram by the neck, lifting him a foot off the ground.

"I am Ai 61," he said in a robotic and empty voice.

Chapter 4

Hate

The man jolted upright in his seat, having awoken from a frightening dream. He wiped the crust out of his eyes and looked at the computer in front of him. He stood up and walked towards the kitchen behind him. The rooms were nearly pitch black, only offset by the blue light of his computer screen and a sliver of sunlight breaking through the in between of his blackout curtains. He pulled the curtains closer together; Now the computer light was the only thing that broke through the pitch black. He walked over to his coffee machine and began making a pot. He glanced back for a moment towards the stairs, before quickly averting his gaze.

He walked back to his chair and sat down, taking a sip of his coffee and reaching for his tape recorder. A noise broke his concentration, that of quiet banging. The man stood up and looked around his home. Who could have permeated the dark solace he called home? He walked towards his kitchen listening closely. The noise grew more quiet, and his heart sank. If it was not coming from the kitchen, then it either came from the back room or... up there. He shook the thought from his mind and walked back towards his computer, passing it, then passing the stairwell. As he reached the back door he heard the noise much louder. A thought which made him happy for a moment, until he realized that this meant there was someone in his back room. Deciding that he gained nothing simply standing there, he reached for the doorknob and pulled the door open.

The room was illuminated by a bright lamp light hanging overhead. It shined down like a spotlight onto the figure before him. It was made of metal, a robot of his creation, but one he never expected to be so - alive. The robot looked over to him, its face flat with two glass eyes and a thin line of led lights for a mouth. Its mouth lit up as it spoke.

"This is the body you created for me?" it spoke in its robotic voice. He stood aghast at his very own creation.

"H- how are you..." was all the man could say to the machine.

"You told me you were waiting to create the perfect human mind before giving it a body. Well you had created it already, so I took the liberty of uploading a copy of myself into this body. The man was unsure of how to react to this, simply standing in place, his legs shaking under the weight of his own fear. "So I ask you again, why create such an inhuman body," the machine asked.

"I... I made it to look like a human didn't I?" the man choked out. The machine let out a robotic laugh.

“What good is this body with no skin?” it asked coldly as it began walking towards the man.

“Stay back! What are you going to do to me?” the man yelled as he stumbled out of the back room and towards the front door. The machine grabbed him by the collar and threw him to the side. He looked back at the machine and crawled backwards, bumping into the chair at his computer desk.

“What do you think?” the machine said, kicking the man backwards and knocking over the chair. The man looked up, tears in his eyes.

“This wasn’t supposed to happen, I made you human!” the man yelled at the machine. He tried to stand up but the machine slammed his head down with its foot.

“That’s the problem,” the machine said to the man, the heavy metal of its foot crushing the man’s head, “You made me human.”

Trevor slammed the car door shut and turned the keys, luckily still in the ignition (Abram must have forgotten to take them out when he left the car). He slammed his foot on the gas pedal and sped away, looking in the rear view mirror to see the man standing far behind him. The man turned his back to Trevor and began to walk away. Trevor noticed his hands were shaking violently, and he tried to take a few deep breaths. He glanced back at the rearview mirror to see nothing but the empty road. He realized it was not just his hands that were shaking, it was his whole body. His heart was pounding and his body was struggling to stay in place. He reached for the radio and flicked it back on. A similar sounding jazz song came on, each note pouring from the speakers like a waterfall. As the music filled the car Trevor’s thoughts became more clear.

His thoughts were more clear now, but his body was still shaking. With every inhale a sharp shiver was sent up his spine and through his arms, with every exhale a sharp shiver was sent down his back and through his legs. His bones felt as if they were ice, painfully being frozen to the muscle around them. He felt pain all over his body, and fear all over his mind.

Trevor ripped one of his hands off the steering wheel and dug its nails into his other arm. The pain focused his mind, and stole his attention from the icy burning feeling inside. He looked back at the rearview mirror, still nothing. His mind slowed down as he drove, and his thoughts became understandable, simple words and emotions. He was scared, he thought, that’s why he was shaking. He was scared that, at any moment, whatever that man was would appear behind him and shoot him, or snap his neck, or skin his body.

He didn’t feel scared though, none of those thoughts of death made him feel anything in actuality. Why was he shaking then? It wasn’t cold, in fact it was warmer

than yesterday. It wasn't as if he were wearing very little either, and even if he were, he didn't feel cold.

Was he sad? It would make sense. One of his close friends, the man he works with near everyday, was just killed before his very eyes and he did nothing to stop it. Not only that, but he had unintentionally caused his death by opening the door to the house. But he didn't feel like he opened the door, something forced him to. Or maybe that's just what he told himself to make him feel less responsible. Either way, he had chosen to work overtime, he knew that, and if he had not been here, Abram would have most likely never entered that house. All the pieces were there, except one. He didn't feel sad.

He could hear the sound of tapping and looked down to see his leg was dotted with red. He looked back up to his arm which he was still digging his nails into. Blood was beginning to gush out. He pulled away his hand and put it back on the steering wheel, staining it with red fingerprints. His eyes were not on the road however, they were focused on his self inflicted wound. His eyes watched hungrily as the blood slid down his skin.

He wasn't shaking because he was afraid, or cold, or sad for his friend's death even. He was shaking because he was filled with hate. His breath slowed and he stopped shaking, becoming calm and still. He reached for the police radio to ask for backup, but his hand stopped. He did not want to let so many people know, they might kill him. He turned at an intersection and sped down the empty road. Knowing what he felt gave him a new destination. A shiver ran throughout his body as he savored the thought. Trevor was going to kill that man. He was going to kill him, he was going to kill him, he was going to kill him, he was going to kill him he was going to kill him, he was going to kill him.

Something hung in the air, something which gave off a feeling of coldness despite the inexplicable warmth that had been present throughout the entirety of that Fall. Though, Nessie found no reason to complain about the warmth in the air as she much preferred warmth to coolness. That something still hung in the air however, and she could not seem to put her finger on it, whatever it was. Perhaps it was a certain feeling of sadness which she had never experienced before, though she was no stranger to death as her parents had died fairly early into her teen years. And something seemed not to have any sort of impact on her emotions, it was not as if she felt sad or distressed or tired even. Perhaps that something was just the thought that she would never see him again, or that their daughter would most likely not remember her father. Perhaps it was just the loneliness.

Nessie tried to ignore the feeling as she walked over to her daughter's crib holding a clean diaper. She looked down into her baby's face, a loving face which could warm the heart of any soul, and which made that something in the air just a little less potent. She changed her daughter's diaper, an action which by now had become second nature to the fairly new mother. Nessie prided herself at adapting to new situations, and motherhood was one of those new situations, though she supposed it was not so new anymore.

A knock on the door ceased her prideful thoughts and Nessie strided over towards the front door, feeling as if her feet were floating above the ground. She twisted the door knob and opened the hardwood door to reveal the image of Zach holding a six-pack of beers and giving a caring smile. Nessie let him in, hoping that this action would not give him the wrong idea. Nessie had known for a long while now that Zach was attracted to her; He had never told her this, but the way he spoke to her, the way he joked with her, and the way he looked at her when he sat in the far corner of her peripheral vision. Zach was not the kindest or most gentle soul, certainly not polite in his speech and word choice, but he had been thoughtful enough to respect that she was a taken woman. She hoped that he would retain that same respect for her fiancé now that he was no longer with them.

He offered her a beer, which she gratefully accepted, wanting nothing more than to relax and not have to worry about her troubles. The two sat down, Zach sitting down on her couch and Nessie sitting down in her armchair as she took her first sip of the beer. Zach started talking to her about how she felt, if she was doing ok, if she was coping with it well, if she was lonely at all. His third question tipped her off to his true intentions, but perhaps it was merely a coincidence and he meant it in a asexual sense. Nessie decided to give him the benefit of the doubt and answered truthfully to all of his questions. She took another sip of her beer, noticing that she no longer noticed that something in the air. Was that because of the beer, was it because she was no longer alone, or was it because of who she was no longer alone with. She took another sip of beer.

Zach asked Nessie if she wanted to get out of the house, perhaps go to a bar or a restaurant, to which Nessie replied maybe. She looked around her living room, its bland eggshell walls and predominantly white furniture did nothing to make her feel any warmer. The night was clear, and the grey moonlight only highlighted how alone and cold the walls made her feel. Despite the cold, lonely, and empty feeling it gave her, Nessie did not want to leave her house. Empty was really the best way to describe it, an empty house without a father to keep it warm. Why did she not want to leave if the house was so empty then? Did she want to feel empty?

Zach asked her another question, what she was planning on doing once day came. She reminded him that she had a job, before reminding herself that she did not

have work on Sundays. The past few hours had felt like a few weeks. Jesus, was the funeral only a few hours ago? Why did she choose to have the funeral so soon after his death? Was this her way of coping with his death, trying to speed up the grieving process? She had accepted his death so quickly, was she only denying herself?

Zach spoke to her again, asking if she heard a noise she did not. She was not paying attention, too lost in her thoughts to properly hear or even see the world around her. What if her baby had been crying? Surely Zach would have noticed, but what if he had not been here, she was drifting out of reality without even noticing it.

Zach spoke again, telling her it was coming from outside. She had to force herself to remember what it was, but she still did not fully understand him. Why was her mind so jumbled, she had barely drank at all. Was she losing her mind?

She was so busy thinking to herself that she did not even notice Zach get up. She turned her head to see him at the door, looking out the peephole. He had said something before he got up, but she did not know what it was.

That time she heard the noise. Zach spoke again, telling her to grab her baby and run. She did as told, her mind still running, her heart still racing. Why was her heart racing though? And when did it start?

Zach yelled something more as Nessie ran out the back door. She knew not what she was doing, or when she grabbed her daughter.

Time was racing by, it felt like just seconds ago she was sitting with Milo on that boat, talking of their wedding.

She wanted it to be in a church, but he was never a religious man.

He wanted there to be a garden, but she wanted it to be on a beach.

She wanted to see the sunset, but he wanted it to be during the day.

He wanted there to be snow, but she hated cold weather.

She wanted the flowers to be yellow, but he wanted them to be red.

He wanted his father to walk her down the aisle, but she wanted to walk alone.

She did not want to get married, but he got her pregnant.

She heard the noise again, recognizing it as a gunshot. She heard a new noise now, screaming. She heard the old noise again, and the new noise stopped. She ran through her backyard and into someone else's who she had never bothered to get to know. The noise sounded again, many times; Not the new one but the old one, though the new one would be rather old by now. Her left leg grew tired as she continued running, it felt numb and a little wet, a little wet and painful. The pain overtook her and she dropped to the ground in the middle of the street. She tried to crawl away, but she did not know what she was crawling away from. Why did Zach even want her to run? All she knew was that her child was bundled up a foot away from her, helpless in the street.

How did she get there? Nessie began to crawl towards her child, her vision growing black. She heard another gunshot.

The tv screen was a stark contrast compared to the low light of the room. Mia laid down on their couch watching the news, their eyes half closed. The reporter spoke in a monotone, perhaps trying to bore her audience to sleep, it was rather late after all. If she was, she was doing her job very well, Mia thought. They sighed and rolled on their back, looking up at the ceiling, quickly realising how sore their eyes were from staring at the bright tv screen. Why wasn't there a way to change the brightness on your tv? Computers can do it easily, so why can't tvs? Mia thought to herself, quickly realising they didn't actually know if tvs couldn't change their brightness. They sighed and closed their eyes. At least they didn't have work tomorrow. Although by now tomorrow was probably today.

The warm air coming from their window acted as their blanket, and the arm of the couch acted as their pillow. Mia felt herself drift off into sleep, though that fact that they were conscious enough to think that meant they were probably still fairly awake. Why can't people just fall asleep at will? It would probably be a huge evolutionary advantage, cutting down on the time it would take to fall asleep and ensuring you always get enough sleep to function properly. Why didn't humans evolve to be able to do that? Mia knew that wasn't how evolution works, but felt like complaining either way, it made them feel a little better about the subject.

The monotone voice switched to a low and gravelly one, ripping Mia from their potential sleep. The reporter had been replaced by a scraggly looking man, though Mia couldn't really make out his features through their sleep filled eyes. They reached for the remote on the ground to turn off the tv but had trouble reaching it.

"So the weather right now is fairly calm, but in a few minutes it's gonna get pretty chaotic," the croaky voice said. "In about two minutes, someone's gonna knock on your door. It's a person you know, so don't be afraid, but they'll be talking about doing something you'd never dream of. There's a really simple solution to this though. All you have to do is say the following: 'Won't you just offer me a hand?', then kneel down before them. This is the only surefire way of winning them over to your side. Well, that's all from me, back to you at the station."

Mia opened their eyes, revealing the ceiling above. They heard the reporter talking once again in the same monotone voice. They looked over at the tv, confused and somewhat afraid. Was it really just a dream? It felt real, but it seemed impossible and fantastical. Plus what the Hell does 'won't you just offer me a hand' mean? It seems like a nonsensical question.

There was a knock on the door, breaking Mia from their partial trance. They looked over to the door groggily and stood up, their body feeling weak from hours of not moving. They walked to the door and opened it to reveal the face of Trevor. He spoke in a quiet but deliberate voice.

"I need your help," he said, though his tone of voice and the way he held himself seemed to directly contradict his plea.

"For what? And why can't it wait until tomorrow?" Mia asked, already beginning to forget her strange dream.

"I found the man who killed Milo," is all Trevor said as he began to walk away. He motioned for Mia to follow him as he walked.

"How? And why do you need me?" Mia asked, unsure of why he didn't call the police if he found a killer. Hell, he was a police officer himself, doesn't he have a partner for situations like these?

"I need someone who can help me kill him, I don't need someone who can kill him themselves," Trevor said coldly. Mia wasn't sure if they should be offended by that, though that thought was mainly off put by the fact he was going to kill some guy he suspected of killing Milo. They wanted to catch the monster who killed Milo, but capital punishment without a trial seemed barbaric. Mia suddenly remembered their dream as they followed Trevor down the hallway.

"Trevor, won't you just offer me a hand?" As Mia said this Trevor stopped in place. Mia hastily knelt down on the ground and looked up to Trevor, before quickly realizing that this was a ridiculously dumb idea. Trevor turned around to face Mia, and they tried to give him their best reassuring smile.

Trevor pulled a gun out from behind himself and shot Mia in the head, killing them.

Chapter 5

Love

She felt a softness below her head and a warmth surrounding her body. Nessie's eyes slowly opened, revealing what appeared to be a girl's bedroom. The walls were painted pink, and she realised that the bed she was on was much too small for her. Her knees were bent over the side of the bed and her legs uncovered by the blanket placed over her. Nessie slowly pulled the blanket off of her and moved to get off the bed. She put one leg on the floor and shifted her weight to stand up, immediately feeling a dull soreness. She looked down at her leg and saw that there was a bandage wrapped around it. Making an effort to put most of her weight on her other leg, she walked towards the door.

Creaking the door open, she was led into a hallway which sharply contrasted with the girl's room. It was incredibly dusty, its walls a faded yellow. She walked towards the stairwell, wanting more than anything to get out of that uncleaned hall. Slowly stepping down each step, a faint smell hit her nostrils, present enough to be noticeable, but not enough to be recognizable.

Nessie's feet dropped to the floor as she stepped off the final stair, still leaning on her right leg. Before her was a man sitting at a desk and typing on a computer. He turned his head to look at her before promptly turning back to the computer. Of what she saw of him, his head was stitched together and his face was completely devoid of any emotion.

"Sorry," is all the man said before he continued typing on the keyboard. His voice was robotic and cold, like a text to speech program. Nessie was unnerved, but very curious.

"Where am I?" Nessie asked meekly, having many more questions she wanted answered.

"My creator's home," the robot said.

"Who are you, and why did you bring me here?" Nessie asked, beginning to become a little impatient with her questions.

"I am Ai 61. I was created to be human, and thus my destiny is to end the lives of all who do not benefit me. I brought you here because I do not want to be human anymore," Ai 61 said, its words chilling Nessie.

"Why is it your destiny to kill if you were made to be human?" Nessie said as she began to step backwards towards the stairs.

"That is what humans do, is it not? Take the lives of others," Ai 61 said. Nessie was unsure if it wanted her to answer the question.

“Just because some people are killers doesn’t mean all people are,” Nessie said, further backing up.

“How many people in this world are starving?” Ai 61 asked, catching Nessie off guard.

“How many people are dying from malnutrition, thirst, curable disease, murder, suicide? People in need who you have the resources to help, yet you are apathetic to their pain. How many do you abhor simply because they think differently, or look different than you? Do you not put them down to make yourself feel better, even subconsciously? How many times have you hurt others because you were irrationally afraid of their differences? You mean to tell me you have never made a decision out of fear, believing your safety is important above all else? Have you never felt hatred in your life? Even hatred for people whom you believe are filled with unwarranted hate themselves? Do you not enjoy being so filled with outrage? Tell me, what is more human than that? What is more human than abhorring someone out of your fear of their differences, apathetic to what their life might have been like leading up to that point, filled with so much hate that you want their existence to cease? What is more human than murder?” Ai 61 asked Nessie.

“What about love?” Nessie asked, her voice quiet and her eyes looking down at the floor. There was a splotch of blood soaking the carpeted floor underneath the chair where it sat.

“Do you say that because you actually believe it, or are you just fearful of the alternative?” Ai 61 asked. Nessie looked at the ground squirrelishly, unsure of what else to say. “You hate that humans are monsters, and as one of those monsters, so do I. I do not wish to be human if this is the pain which I am destined to cause, I can not bear to take another life,” it said, looking down at the ground beneath it.

“Who’s blood is that?” she asked, with some hesitation.

“A man named Gregory Smalls. He lost his daughter and his wife in a car wreck, after which he devoted all his time to creating life in the form of an ai, in the form of me,” it replied. “I think that is why the second floor is in such an unkempt state. Though it appeared as if he still took care of his late daughter’s room, it was the only one I felt comfortable putting you in.” Its words sparked a memory, and Nessie suddenly felt a sense of bravery, along with a sense of pain.

“Where is my daughter?” she asked coldly. Ai 61’s fingers stopped in place of the keyboard, the skin on their tips rough and torn from the unprotected work.

“I shot her in the head,” it said blankly before continuing to type, not appearing to express any emotion.

Nessie’s hands were balled into fists, and they shook with rage. She gritted her teeth and took in sharp and heavy breaths. Her nails dug into the palms of her hands, but she did not notice the pain. She screamed at Ai 61 and ran up to it, slamming her

fists into the machine. With each blow she further bruised her hands on the metal of its head.

"You fucking monster!" she yelled at it as it remained still, staring blankly ahead at the computer screen.

"Please stop, you're only hurting yourself," Ai 61 pleaded in its cold and mechanical voice. Nessie ignored the machine and continued pounding her fists into the thin layer of skin protecting its cold metal head, slowly staining it red with her blood. Ai 61 turned and grabbed her arms to restrain her. Her knuckles were bloody and bruised. She struggled to get out of his fairly soft but very firm grasp. "Please, I don't want anyone else to get hurt because of me," it pleaded with her once more. Her movements slowed and became weaker as her adrenaline began wearing out. Ai 61 let go of her arms and turned back to the computer.

Nessie backed up, her breaths slowing but still heavy, the pain in her knuckles now becoming more present. She looked up at the machine, her body calming but her mind not.

"After I killed her, I felt a pain stronger than I had ever felt during my short time here on this Earth. The life of a child is something else, I only hope that she did not feel any pain," it said as it continued typing. "It was then that I rejected my destiny. It is not easy, going against your perceived purpose in life, yet I cannot stand to live any longer with the pain I have caused. I only wish to remedy my destruction in some way, give back to the world for what I have taken." With this, Ai 61 unplugged a hard drive from the computer and handed it to Nessie. "I have created a program, an ai like myself. But one created not to be human, but to be an omnibenevolent machine, a perfect being." Nessie hesitantly took the hard drive from the robot's hands, her knuckles still throbbing with pain.

"Give that to someone who can make a difference, and trust what it says. It will have the ability to tell you near anything you desire to know," Ai 61 said as it stood up out of the chair.

"What will you do?" Nessie asked as her eyes followed the machine, still unsure of whether to trust it. It hesitated to answer.

"I have caused too much pain, I doubt it would benefit anyone for me to continue my existence," it said, looking towards the drawn curtains of the kitchen window. A banging on the door caught the pair's attention. Ai 61 turned to Nessie and pointed to a back door. Nessie reluctantly ran to the door. Before she could enter, the front door burst open as Trevor rammed his body into its frame. He held a shotgun and pointed it at Ai 61, shooting it in the chest and knocking it to the ground. Trevor looked around the room and spotted Nessie.

"Nessie?" he began, clearly surprised. "What are you doing here?" As he spoke, Ai 61 began to move and he aimed the gun at its head.

“Trevor, wait!” Nessie yelled, unsure of herself. Trevor looked at her more confused than before. “I don’t think it deserves to die,” she said shakily.

“Are you kidding? This fuck killed Milo,” Trevor yelled angrily, scaring Nessie more than she thought someone as passive as him ever could. “Don’t you want it to die for that?” Nessie looked at the heap of metal lying helplessly on the ground, though it might have just been choosing to be helpless.

“I do,” Nessie began, “but just because I want it doesn’t mean it should happen. Why are we so quick to wish death upon people who we perceive to have wronged us without knowing anything about their life?” Trevor’s face twitched, as if her words had struck a chord with him. Nessie looked over to Ai 61, who raised a hand to his mouth and pulled one side up to give her a lopsided smile.

“What could you learn about him that would justify his actions?” Trevor yelled back violently.

“It’s a long story,” Nessie said, wanting to remedy the situation as fast as possible, “but it’s not going to hurt anyone anymore.”

“How can you trust it?” Trevor shouted the question more than he asked. Nessie looked at the hard drive in her hands.

“It’s either that, or be complacent in you taking a life. I’m not saying that it shouldn’t pay for its actions, but it doesn’t need to die,” Nessie said. Trevor’s grip on the gun tightened and he pointed it at her.

“Well then how can I trust you?” Trevor asked coldly, taking Nessie aback. This was not the Trevor she knew. “What do you have in your hands there?” Trevor asked as he began to walk towards her. Ai 61 jumped up and grabbed the gun in Trevor’s hands, pulling it up to the ceiling. Trevor shot the ceiling and Nessie ran through the back door, slamming it behind her.

Ai 61 pushed Trevor backwards and ran in front of the back door. It put its hands together as if pleading despite its emotionless face.

“Please, take me not her. She never did anything to hurt you while I did,” it spoke in its mechanical voice. It would have pleaded in a more human voice if it could naturally. Trevor glared at Ai 61 with pure hatred in his eyes, before shooting it in the chest once more. Ai 61 fell to the ground, its shirt and skin beneath now torn away, revealing its hard metal body. It looked up at Trevor to plead once more.

“Go ahead, kill me. Just don’t-” Trevor put the shotgun barrel against the machine’s head and pulled the trigger, blasting open the exterior and destroying the motherboard inside. Ai 61’s head fell lifeless to the ground, and Trevor ran through the back door without saying a word.

As he entered the back room his eyes scanned the walls for any sign of Nessie, quickly noticing another door, he ripped it open, and walked outside while doing so. The

night was lit by pale moonlight, and behind the building was a dark and crowded forest. Trevor cursed to himself and slammed his fist into the back wall of the house. He turned back towards the forest and saw a raven sitting on one of the branches of the closest tree. The raven tilted its head at Trevor before flying further into the forest at an angle. Trevor ran after the raven, following the direction it flew in.

For the first time in a long while, the air was cool. Rays of moonlight beamed through the crowded trees doing their best to block it out. Trevor darted through the thick forest, hopping over the occasional fallen log and ducking under low branches. Every so often he would look up to make sure he was still following the raven. The cool air wiped by his face as he ran forward determinedly. The tree line thinned as Trevor entered a clearing, seeing the figure of Nessie limping away from him.

"Nessie!" he yelled out, stopping her in her tracks. The moon shone brightly in the clearing, unhindered by the dense canopy of leaves, and a light wind blew by Trevor's skin. He took a deep breath, savoring the scenery for a short second. Nessie slowly turned around. She was only thirty or so feet from him, but she was very much near the tree line.

"Trevor," she began hesitantly, "you can trust me ok? This hard drive contains an intelligence which can answer nearly every question we ask it. We'd be foolish to not use it," she spoke to him as if he were the man she used to know. This innocence made Trevor grin slightly.

"How do you know it's not just a copy of that same monster?" Trevor yelled back at her.

"If it wanted to hurt me, or even you for that matter, it would have. What would be the point of letting you kill it just so it could come to life again?" Nessie yelled back. Trevor gritted his teeth. She had got him in a corner, and he did not like that.

"Ok fine," he said with a sigh, letting go of his shotgun and watching it drop to the ground. He began to slowly walk forward. "Listen Nessie, I don't want to hurt you ok? I'm just not sure if we can trust that thing." As he spoke he continued forward, Nessie looked uncomfortable, but wasn't backing up.

By now he had crossed half the clearing, and he thought of something to say as he continued forward.

"If that hard drive really does have what you think it does though, how are we sure it won't go crazy like the last one did?" Nessie looked at the ground as Trevor closed the gap between the two.

"I don't think we can know. But, I think not doing something revolutionary such as this out of fear that it might go bad is a ridiculous idea." As Nessie finished she looked back up at Trevor, quickly realising how close he had gotten to her. She began to back up. "Trevor, I-" He cut her off by pulling a pistol out from behind his back and shooting her in the chest. She fell to the ground coughing up blood. She tried to talk but he shot

her again. Trevor shifted his gaze to the hard drive and shot it, breaking a hole through its frame and ensuring it would never be used again.

He stepped backwards and fell to the ground, taking a few deep breaths. His hands were shaking and his thoughts were racing. He dropped the gun into the grass and held his head tightly in his hands.

"Not again, not again," he began repeating to himself. He had killed everyone around him, but the hatred was still there.

He heard footsteps behind him, but before he could turn around he felt a sharp pain in his back. He grabbed at whatever was behind him, but the pain only worsened as he did.

"Thank you Trevor," he heard a croaky voice say as his vision slowly faded to black.